

PLAY AND PROSPER · TRAVEL THE WORLD, BECOME YOURSELF

Free to Go

From guarding one office to a hundred countries

by Lily

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Lily

LILY • Dallas



Business restructuring coach for founder-led brands

Producer & translator of 20+ bestsellers

Co-founder, Play and Prosper

AI master’ s graduate in the US, producer and translator of 20+ bestselling books, creator of 100+ AI agents. Lily helps personal brands, seasoned founders and business owners restructure for the AI era: turning abilities into assets and experience into products. She leads a hundred authors across eight time zones to write books together, using clear systems to grow a business without the grind. Play and prosper.

Free to Go

From guarding one office to a hundred countries

01 It won't work without me

My dear daughter was studying in another city. One year she came home for the holidays.

I picked her up at the airport, and instead of going home I took her to the office first: there was a pile of work waiting. She's quick with her hands, so I gave her some company tasks, and she came to work with me.

At night, back home, I was still at my computer, still with unfinished work. She sat beside me, telling me about her friends and school. I listened while I kept working.

She opened her laptop too, and went off to do her own things.

Over the next few days it wasn't only me who was busy: I had filled her days to the brim as well.

Finally one day she couldn't hold it in:

"Mommy, you plan this and that for me, but you never asked how I feel. When will you spend time with me?"

I looked up at her. Her eyes were full of tears.

Mine filled up too.

That night I asked myself: all this busyness, what is it for?

In those years I ran my own company. Staff, clients; retail, wholesale, e-commerce, and later real estate. The business kept spreading, and I did everything with my own hands.

When I had a job, it was nine to five; however busy, there were weekends, and at home I didn't have to think about anything. Once I had my own company, it became seven days a week, from morning to night. The staff went home; I stayed in the office.

I wasn't busy.

I couldn't get away.

There was one sentence I had believed for half my life:

It won't work without me.

02 No grown-up at home

I learned that sentence when I was very small.

My father worked in Harbin; my mother taught at a commune school outside Shuangcheng. Back then it was called living apart. On ordinary days, our family was scattered.

On weekends, my mother was busy in the kitchen and I stood on the road outside the door. As it got dark, at the far end of the road a tall man on a bicycle would appear and come closer and closer. My father. Six foot two, tall and handsome. Forty li he rode from Harbin, covered in dust.

The moment he stepped into the yard, the family was whole. We sat around the table and ate a hot meal my mother had cooked.

But he came home only once a week.

On the other days, my mother went to teach and I took my little brother out to play. Other kids dared to hit us, because there was no grown-up at home.

My brother was younger than me. But from the day we got beaten, he knew he had to protect his big sister.

That's why my brother is a better fighter than I am.

At eighteen, when my admission letter arrived, my father started getting ready. He was an intellectual, but he was good with his hands. He found some wood and worked on it slowly in the yard. Sawed it, planed it, fitted it together piece by piece into a trunk.

Then he painted it a pale glacier blue.

Last of all, he fitted a lock.

On the first day of school he carried that trunk on his shoulder and saw me into college.

Later, with only the last step of my studies left, I dropped out and went abroad, for a dream of freedom.

Other people brought two big suitcases; I brought one. My family had worked it out: she can't carry two.

In those years my father couldn't come home because he was earning a home for us.

Later I couldn't go home because I was guarding a company.

I had become the one who wasn't there.

03 Handing it over, one thing at a time

After that night, I wanted to travel. Not for seven days. For a month, or longer.

But I couldn't even get away for three days.

So I started doing one thing: unloading the work in my hands, one task at a time.

There was no AI back then. First I hired a virtual assistant in India named Shilpi. She worked remotely; we never met.

Whatever could be handed over, I taught her one by one. It started with her alone; later she built a team spread across several countries.

At first I still watched them work and gave feedback.

After a while I let go. So what if they made a mistake? It was no big deal.

Our clients were scattered around the world too; time zone after time zone, the company ran twenty-four hours a day.

The company kept turning, and I no longer had to.

On the days I was gone, it still brought in money.

When I next looked up, a single trip could last a month, forty-five days. One phone, one laptop.

The sky didn't fall.

04 All I had to do was follow along

In October 2026 there was a book launch in Guangzhou, which Deng Xiuwen had set up with me; everyone calls her Sister Yaotiao. The details came one after another: venue, program, guests, materials…

In the old days I would have done all of it myself.

This time I didn't. I sent Zou Na a voice message, just one sentence:

"Can you run it?"

She said, "Sure!"

I could hear how confident she was.

In the days that followed, the hard part wasn't letting go. It was not taking it back.

She settled the plan with the team and went off to make it happen.

After all these years, I still worried: is the budget enough? Will people come? How many have signed up?

I really wanted to ask, to step in.

But every time my hand was about to reach out, I asked myself one question:

Will this work without me?

Of course it would.

So I stayed out of it.

On the day of the launch, the morning was at the Cantonese Embroidery Garden. The moment I walked in, I was stunned.

From the floor to the tables, "Play and Prosper" was everywhere. Tablecloths, little ornaments you could pick up and spin. The gifts too.

I hadn't chosen a single one.

In the afternoon we moved to the Hanmo Garden. I followed the volunteers' arrangements: bow, take my seat, front row center.

More than twenty authors had flown in from around the world, bringing family and friends; every seat was taken.

One by one the authors went on stage to share. They spoke about their own lives, with their own families in the audience.

For many, it was a first in their lives.

Banmu Fangtang went up too. He talked about writing his book, and partway through, he couldn't go on.

His wife walked up on stage and stood beside him.

The program, the venue, every step: none of it went through my hands.

I sat in the audience. All I had to do was follow along.

On stage, Sister Yaotiao called me "Mr. Qianbaihe", using the old honorific xiansheng.

It was the first time anyone had called me that.

I truly didn't feel worthy. Madame Soong Ching-ling, Yang Jiang: the word xiansheng is heavy.

Later I understood: xiansheng originally just means "one born earlier." I wasn't born much earlier, and I'm not more learned than anyone; I just stepped onto the stage a little sooner.

That day I didn't do anything with my own hands.

The event was run by others, and that "xiansheng" was given by others too.

05 One question

For more than twenty years, I've made my way by one question.

Will this work without me?

In the past, the answer was people.

Now I ask one more: can AI do this?

Bills and reports: it sorts them and waits for me; on our monthly money-counting day I just open it and take a look.

Material I should read: it goes through it first and picks out what matters.

I even asked it about investing: can you do this? It said yes. So little by little, I let go.

Whatever I can hand to it, I've handed over.

It works, and I watch with a cup of tea.

When you get down to it, it's just a few steps:

Three steps to get free

Being unable to get away isn't about lacking time. It's thinking that nothing can happen without you.

Look: go over what you did today, from morning to night. No lists, no writing.

Ask: ask each one out loud: Will this work without me?

Yes: then stop doing it.

Someone else can do it: then let them. If there's no one, let AI do it; if neither works, set a rule and follow the rule from now on.

It really has to be me: then keep it. That is your gift, not your burden. Never hand this kind away; hand it away and you are no longer you.

A whole task depending on you doesn't mean every step depends on you. If it's all "it really has to be me", ask again: which step takes the most time? That step: will it work without me?

Swap: take the time you've freed and spend it on the thing that really has to be you.

Your hands will still itch. Every time you want to reach back in, ask the question again.

Ask it for ten days and you'll find: very few things truly can't do without you.

Look · Ask · Swap: swap out time, and win yourself back.

I didn't leave the freed time empty.

I used it to see the world, to volunteer, to design courses, and to be with the family I love.

A hundred countries in a lifetime: fifty-four so far, forty-six still ahead.

This year I booked an entire island for five days, to take the big Play and Prosper family there together.

Which route to take, where to stay, what to do on the island: that really has to be me. I scout it myself and design it myself.

I love this. No one can do it for me.

06 Free to go

This April I went to Morocco.

Why Morocco? I asked my AI agent, and it said go there.

The flight was booked, the hotel wasn't. Waiting for a connection in Barcelona, just before boarding, I had the AI book one.

One phone, one laptop, one glacier-blue suitcase: still that same color.

In the suitcase lay a copy of Play and Prosper: a whole group of names, traveling with me.

And off I went.

The afternoon I landed, I hung up my clothes in my room and sat down. Outside the window was Casablanca.

My first time there; I'd leave in two days.

On my phone, not a single message was waiting for me to decide.

The world is my office.

In the years I couldn't get away, I was always afraid something would go wrong. Afraid that if I let go, this would collapse and that would fall apart.

Later I let go, one thing at a time.

Of everything that might collapse, not one thing did.

Only one thing collapsed: that sentence, "It won't work without me."

Only then did I understand: what held me was never those things. It was believing they all belonged to me. It was not being able to let go.

Once I let go, my hands were free.

The year my daughter graduated from university, my family and I flew out. After the ceremony we all traveled together.

Later we went to Iceland as well. These days, when we travel, sometimes she's the one leading me.

That night many years ago, she asked me: Mommy, when will you spend time with me?

This time, I'm here.

You have your own "it won't work without me" too.

Pick one thing and ask it out loud:

Will this work without me?

Let go, and you're free to go.

Lily, in Shanghai

Let go, and you’re free to go.

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and reserve a signed copy of the book

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